Figure 5.1, we would be able to see this directly; we would also see, undeniably, that the person is *you* at your current age. For these events, situated decades ago, to make sense, you *must* time-travel back to 1965. What's more, from our outside perspective we can see your father asking you a question just after 11:50 p.m. on December 31, 1965, looking frightened, rushing away, and meeting your mother at midnight; a little further along the loaf, we can see your parents' wedding, your birth, your ensuing childhood, and, later on, your stepping into the time machine. If time travel to the past were possible, we could no longer explain events at one time solely in terms of events at earlier times (from any given perspective); but the totality of events would necessarily constitute a sensible, coherent, noncontradictory story.

As emphasized in the last section, this doesn't, by any stretch of the imagination, signify that time travel to the past is possible. But it does suggest strongly that the purported paradoxes, such as preventing your own birth, are themselves born of logical flaws. If you time-travel to the past, you can't change it any more than you can change the value of pi. If you travel to the past, you are, will be, and always were part of the past, the very same past that leads to your traveling to it.

From the outside perspective of Figure 5.1, this explanation is both tight and coherent. Surveying the totality of events in the spacetime loaf, we see that they interlock with the rigid economy of a cosmic crossword puzzle. Yet, from your perspective on December 31, 1965, things are still puzzling. I declared above that even though you may be determined to keep your parents from meeting, you can't succeed in the classical approach to this problem. You can watch them meet. You can even facilitate their meeting, perhaps inadvertently as in the story I've told. You can travel back in time repeatedly, so there are many of you present, each intent on preventing your parents' union. But to succeed in preventing your parents from meeting would be to change something with respect to which the concept of change is meaningless.

But, even with the insight of these abstract observations, we can't help asking: What stops you from succeeding? If you are standing at the party at 11:50 p.m. and see your young mother, what stops you from whisking her away? Or, if you see your young father, what stops you from—oh,